Writing a Collaborative Paper

Establishing Group Expectations

Before beginning, your group should address the following questions:

- What is everyone's preferred method of communication?
- Would the group prefer to organize and write virtually, or schedule a specified number of meetings to prepare content?
- How quickly should group members respond to messages? For example, within 24 hours or 48 hours?
- Are there days/times when someone generally cannot work?
- How will the group make decisions when people disagree about interpretation?
- How will the group handle conflict with group management?
- What does the group consider a reasonable amount of notice if someone cannot meet an internal deadline?
- Are there any boundaries that should be established?
    - This can include windows of communication (ex: not after 10 pm), terminology that shouldn't be used (be it about the topic or more general, like no swear words), or specific topics (ex: no personal political beliefs, no jokes about the topic, etc.)
    - A boundary for one is a boundary for all.
- Does the group want to bring/send the paper to the Writing Center for feedback?

Writing Shared Sections

One of the aspects of this paper that most students are likely unfamiliar with is writing shared sections. While there are a few ways to approach shared sections, this is the approach I would suggest:

-Step 1: Every student creates a separate bullet list of items they believe should be discussed in each group section (preferably while writing their individual sections).
-Step 2: Combine everyone's bullets for each shared section (Introduction, Critical Eval. I, Critical Eval. II, Critical Eval. III, and Critical Eval. IV)
-Step 3: Group bullet points based on similarity and eliminate redundancies/ condense as possible.
-Step 4: Determine if any items need to be deleted or moved elsewhere.
-Step 5: Arrange in the most cohesive narrative order.
-Step 6: Turn bullet points into sentences and check flow.

With this approach, if every group member is thorough in Step 1, the remaining steps can be completed in one meeting.

Setting Group Deadlines

I HIGHLY encourage students to set internal timelines. In particular, I would suggest setting internal deadlines for the following items:

- Read all articles – by Month and Day
- Write individual section for Source 1 – by Month and Day
- Write individual section for Source 2 – by Month and Day
- Write individual section for Source 3 – by Month and Day
- Write individual section for Source 4 – by Month and Day
- Write individual section for Source 5 – by Month and Day
- Provide bullet points for shared sections – by Month and Day
- Complete introduction – by Month and Day
- Complete critical evaluation of health communication – by Month and Day
- Complete references – by Month and Day
- Edit 1 complete – by Month and Day
- Paper sent to writing center (if applicable) – by Month and Day
- Edit 2 complete – by Month and Day
- Group approval (when everyone needs to agree that they approve of the final version) – by Month and Day
- Paper submitted – by Month and Day

Create a Group Plan Document

For any group project, it can be extremely helpful to create a Group Plan Document (and it is required for this paper). Within it, you can track communication expectations, meeting details, assignment details (ex: who was assigned each aspect, who is turning in the final document to Canvas, etc.), the group's timeline, the conflict management plan and provide space to work through any questions you may come across while going through the source (ex: any questions you have about what myocarditis is).

Everyone Edits

Rather than have one person in charge of editing, have every group member review every section. This is the best way to catch any errors, while preventing any one student from being responsible if an error slips through.

Conflict Management

Address any potential conflicts early. For any potential conflict, identify if it is an academic disagreement or a group-functioning concern.

Example academic disagreement: “I believe the language in this source was more alarming than informative.”

Solution for academic disagreements: Provide evidence behind your specific interpretation, and ask the entire group to weigh in, to decide as a group how to make the flow cohesive.

Example group-functioning concern: A member misses an internal deadline.

Solution: Use the conflict resolution your group decided on before emotions were high (this is why it’s important to create a plan at the beginning of the project).

Conflict Resolution Plan Example:

- Step 1 – Ask not Attack: Contact the group member directly (not in the group chat) to ask if there is a reason behind the conflict (be it a missed deadline, way of phrasing a comment, or something else).
  Note: This message can be sent by anyone (whoever notices the problem)
- Step 2 – Explain Concern: While things deadlines may be straightforward, conflicts based on tone or comments may need to be explained from the other standpoint (I felt ____ when you ____ because ____”).
- Step 3 – Establish New Goal: If the timeline needs to be adjusted, add it to the Group Plan document and notify the other group members. If the conflict was about communication/ wording, come up with a new plan for discussing that topic.
- Step 4 – Group Check-In: If the problem is not resolved after the first point of contact, bring the concern to the group, and ask for ideas on resolving the conflict.
- Step 5 – Ask for Help: If the group cannot come to a resolution, ask the instructor for help. Do not let it get to the point of angry or accusatory messages.

As a note, contacting the instructor the night the paper is due to report a group member is not effective conflict management. Be preemptive in conflict resolution, so there is time to find a solution.

Pro-Tips

- Focus discussions on the communication styles within the sources, rather than whether you agree/ disagree with the argument. Similarly, avoid any disparaging comments about either side of the argument.
- Remember that you are not being asked to agree with your group members or get them to agree with you. You are being asked to work effectively with them.
- Use the terminology appropriate to the academic source/ content, rather than using fad, biased, or derogatory terminology. If terminology is different per source, include it in the paper (how does each version impact communication?).

- You don’t have to write the sections in order. It is okay to complete the introduction towards the end, when you are more familiar with the content (similar to how we write the abstract for a research paper last).
- For every sentence you write, ask yourself if you are summarizing what the source said or how they said it (this will help keep it from becoming a bibliography).
- Dedicate at least one round of editing to voice/ flow cohesiveness. This is one paper, not a conglomerate of 5 papers.
- Be careful to keep each individual’s aspect unique. While there may be some overlap, make sure that your individual writing is only addressing your assigned aspect.
- For however long you think you will need to complete a task, double it. Not only can things go wrong, but it is quite likely that this is the first time you are approaching a paper this way. Give yourself any extra space that you can to work through problems.
- Check in with your group regularly, not just about deadlines. They are working through the same articles as you, so may be struggling with similar questions.